

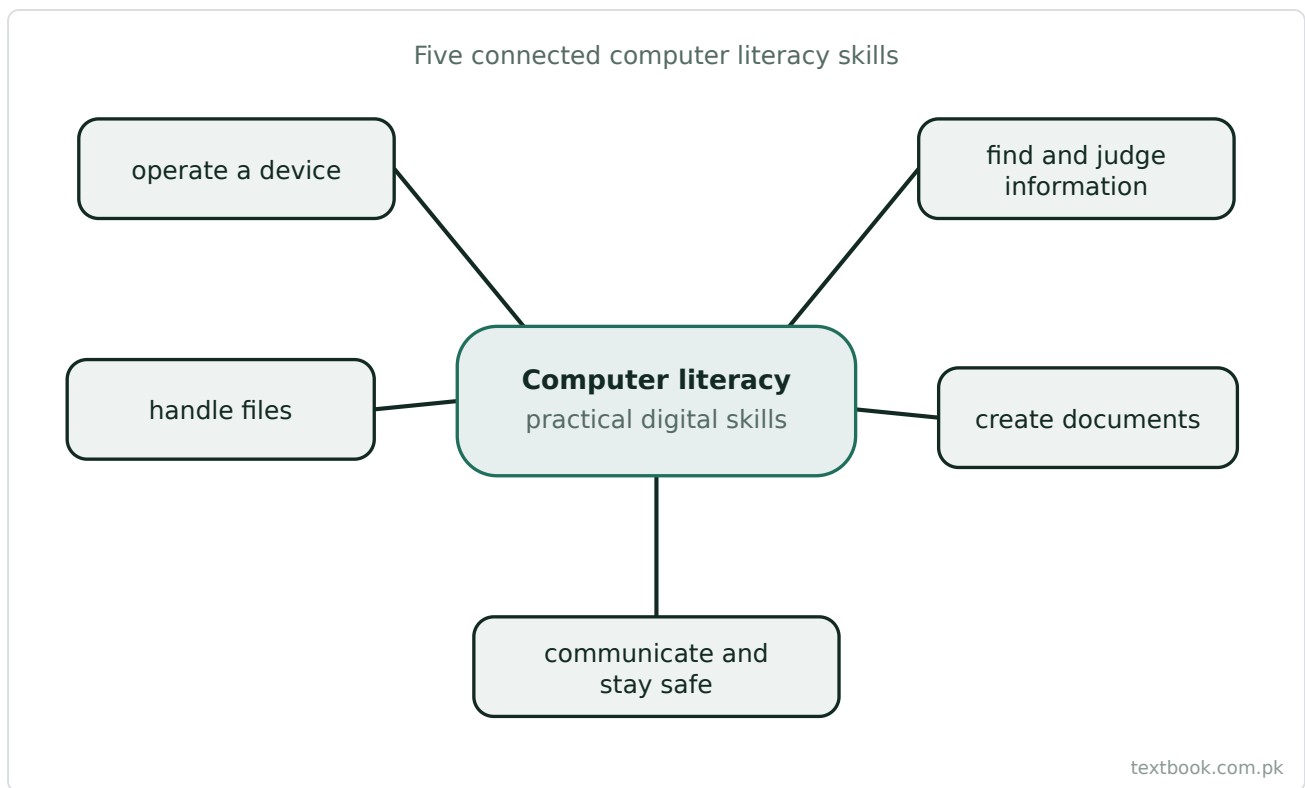
Draft - expert review pending

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Topic 1.1 - Computer literacy and why it matters

A real classroom situation

Miss Saima is a trainee teacher on practicum at a government girls' primary school in Hyderabad. On her first day, the head teacher hands her the attendance register and asks her to enter the week's figures into the school's computer and email the file to the district office by noon. Saima has used a mobile phone every day for years. She can chat, watch videos and scroll social media without thinking. But a spreadsheet, a file attachment and an email to an official address are new to her, and her hands freeze at the keyboard. Being comfortable with a phone, she discovers, is not the same as being computer literate.



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Explanation

Concept and scope of computer literacy

Computer literacy is the knowledge and skill needed to use computers and related technology effectively. It covers more than knowing where the keys are. A computer-literate person can operate a computer or phone, save and find files, create documents and presentations, search for information and judge whether it is trustworthy, communicate using email and messaging tools, and protect themselves from common online risks.

Many people think computer literacy means knowing how to type. That is a real misunderstanding. Typing is one small motor skill. The European Commission's digital competence framework, DigComp, describes digital competence in five areas: information and data literacy, communication and collaboration, digital content creation, safety, and problem solving (Vuorikari, Kluzer, and Punie, 2022). A person who can type but cannot tell a reliable website from a fake one, or cannot attach a file to an email, is not computer literate in this fuller sense. Bourgeois and colleagues (2019) make the same point from the systems side:

using technology well means understanding the people, processes and technology together, not just pressing keys.

For a teacher, the scope is practical. Consider the tasks in the figure below. Each one needs a different mix of skills, and a teacher meets all of them in a normal term.

Everyday school tasks: matching ICT skills

Task	Device skill	File and document skill	Information skill
Enter attendance in a spreadsheet	Use keyboard and mouse	Enter data and save workbook	Check names and totals
Email the file to the office	Use keyboard and network connection	Attach the correct file	Use the office email address
Find a lesson video online	Use browser and speakers	Open and save the video link	Search and judge the source
Prepare a parent notice in a word processor	Use keyboard and mouse	Format and save the notice	Check audience and details
Back up exam records to a USB drive	Use USB port and storage drive	Copy and name the backup	Verify records are complete

Read each row across to identify the skills needed for one task.

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Importance of ICT in education, work and society

Information and Communication Technology (ICT) is the family of technologies that handle information and communication together: computers, phones, networks, the internet, and the software that runs on them. Notice what this definition includes. A phone call over the internet, a school's Wi-Fi router and a spreadsheet are all ICT. Many people think ICT means computers only, but the term deliberately covers networks and communication devices too.

In education, ICT changes what teachers can do. UNESCO's ICT Competency Framework for Teachers (2018) describes three levels of teacher development with technology: acquiring knowledge (learning to use the tools), deepening knowledge (using them to improve subject teaching), and creating knowledge

(helping pupils produce their own digital work). A teacher who is computer literate can pull a science experiment video into a lesson in a village school, keep clean digital records, and eventually guide pupils in their own projects. The Higher Education Commission of Pakistan has also made ICT and digital literacy a stated priority for universities and teacher education (HEC, n.d.).

In work, ICT has become the default way organisations run. Salaries, records, orders and reports all move through computers. In Pakistan, most everyday services now have a digital side: banks send SMS alerts, government offices accept online forms, and mobile wallets such as Easypaisa and JazzCash move money without a bank branch. A person who cannot use these systems depends on someone else for ordinary tasks.

In society, ICT shapes how people connect and get information. Pakistan's telecom regulator, the PTA, reported more than 190 million cellular subscriptions and roughly 140 million broadband connections in 2025 (Pakistan Telecommunication Authority, 2025). Most of that access is through mobile phones, not desktop computers. That single fact shapes what computer literacy means in this country: the phone in a family's pocket is often their main computer, their bank and their library at once.

Activity: ICT skills audit

Work in pairs. About 20 minutes.

1. Each partner takes the five task rows from the second figure (attendance in a spreadsheet, emailing a file, finding a lesson video, preparing a notice, backing up records) and privately rates themselves for each task: "can do alone", "can do with help", or "cannot do yet".
2. Compare your ratings. Where the two of you differ, the stronger partner explains exactly how they would do the task, step by step.
3. Together, agree on two skills each of you will build during this course, and write them at the back of your notebook. You will return to this list in Unit 6.

Check your understanding

1. Define computer literacy in one sentence of your own. (*Remember*)

2. List three things a computer-literate teacher can do that go beyond typing.
(*Understand*)
3. A clerk in a Sindh school office can type quickly but cannot attach a file to an email. Using the concept of computer literacy, explain in two sentences what skill is missing and why it matters for the office. (*Apply*)
4. Name the five areas of digital competence in the DigComp framework.
(*Remember*)

Summary

Computer literacy is the full set of skills for using technology effectively: operating devices, handling files, creating documents, finding and judging information, and communicating safely. It is not typing. ICT covers computers, phones, networks and the internet together, and it now runs through education, work and daily life in Pakistan, where most people reach the internet through a phone.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can define computer literacy in my own words.
- ☐ I can name at least four skills that computer literacy covers beyond typing.
- ☐ I can explain, with a Pakistan example, why ICT matters for a teacher.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask your cooperating teacher to list the ICT tasks they do in a normal week (attendance, results, emails, printing, messaging parents). Note each task and mark which ones you could already help with and which you could not yet. Bring the list back to class.

Summative task

Write a short paragraph (150 to 200 words) arguing why computer literacy matters for a teacher in a Sindh government school today. Support your argument with at least two specific school tasks and one fact about technology access in Pakistan.

Marking guide (8 marks):

- Definition used correctly, not just "typing": 2 marks.
- Two or more specific school tasks named and connected to skills: 3 marks.
- One relevant Pakistan fact or example used as evidence (Analyse): 2 marks.
- Clear, complete sentences within the word limit: 1 mark.

Further reading

- Vuorikari, R., Kluzer, S., & Punie, Y. (2022). *DigComp 2.2: The Digital Competence Framework for Citizens*. Publications Office of the European Union. <https://doi.org/10.2760/115376>
- Bourgeois, D. T., Smith, J. L., Wang, S., & Mortati, J. (2019). *Information Systems for Business and Beyond* (2nd ed.), chapters 1 and 11. Open Textbook Library.
<https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/information-systems-for-business-and-beyond>
- UNESCO. (2018). *UNESCO ICT Competency Framework for Teachers* (Version 3). <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000265723>

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